Lesson 52: Good Writing: Model Paragraphs and Essays, Topics and Rubrics

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 9.1 Qualities of Good Writing; 9.2 Samples of Good Paragraph Writing; 9.3 Samples of Good Essay Writing; 10.1 Suggested Writing Topics; 10.2 Sample Grading Rubrics.

In this lesson

This is the last lesson of the English program. You will review what makes college writing good, judge real student paragraphs and essays with a grading rubric, and then write a final essay that brings together the skills of the whole course: a clear thesis, evidence from sources with citations, a counterargument, hedging, cohesion and academic style. Assessing your own work with a rubric is how you will keep improving in your university study.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain six qualities of good college writing.
- Assess a paragraph or an essay with a rubric for development, organization and mechanics.
- Edit student writing for grammar, word choice and overgeneralized claims.
- Plan, write and revise a final argumentative essay with a thesis, cited evidence, a counterargument and hedged claims.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
rubric	a scoring guide that describes each level of quality for each criterion	1 = minimal, 2 = adequate, 3 = strong, 4 = excellent
criterion (plural: criteria)	a standard for judging something	Development, organization and mechanics are the criteria of Rubric #1.
development	how well an essay responds to the topic with a focused thesis	The main idea is clearly addressed with a strong thesis.
organization	the introduction, topic sentences, supporting details and conclusion	The essay is well organized.
mechanics	spelling, grammar and punctuation	Hardly any spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
engaging	holding the reader's interest	Good college writing is easy to read and engaging.
"dumbed down"	(informal) made too simple	Easy to read is not the same as "dumbed down".
concise	expressing ideas in few words, with nothing unnecessary	Good writing is clear and concise.
effective	succeeding in its purpose	Effective writing accomplishes its purpose.
reader expectations	what the intended reader expects to find	Understand the assignment to meet reader expectations.
overgeneralization	a claim about all or every case that the evidence does not support	"All American are obeying the rules while they drive."

Rules and explanations

Six qualities of good writing

Writer Edward P. Bailey says that good college writing:

1. **follows certain academic rules**: use words correctly, form sentences with proper grammar and build logical paragraphs. Knowing the rules lets you be creative and clear. When audience expectations and standards pull in different directions, **reader understanding** is the deciding factor.
2. **is easy to read and engaging**: not "dumbed down". The truly excellent writer explains complex ideas so that the reader understands, with a brilliant illustrative example, definitions of unfamiliar words, or dynamic, specific verbs.
3. **attracts the reader**: will they want to read it? State early how your writing meets the reader's needs (a "what's in it for me" strategy): it answers a question, solves a problem, argues a point or contrasts two views.

The book adds that good writing:

4. **meets the reader's expectations**: know your reader, and understand the assignment and its purpose.
5. **is clear and concise**: communicate all the intended information accurately, with as little misunderstanding as possible.
6. **is efficient and effective**: understand the goals and desired results; effective writing accomplishes its purpose. Writing is both a process and a product, so it always needs revision.

The student samples

The sample paragraphs and essays are printed "exactly as the student wrote them", with some errors. Read them for their strengths (a clear topic, a personal example, a simple structure) and practise

editing them. Essays #2 and #4 and Rubric #3 are only pictures in the book, so they may be missing from your material.

Rubric #1 (high intermediate and advanced writing)

	1 = minimal	2 = adequate	3 = strong	4 = excellent
Development	does not respond to the topic, or not focused	thesis, but imprecise or not focused enough	clear thesis that addresses the assignment	strong thesis that clearly addresses the main idea
Organization	no clear introduction, conclusion or topic sentences	passable; thin support; some topic sentences; weak introduction and/or conclusion	generally well organized; effective details; good introduction and/or conclusion; appropriate topic sentences	well organized; effective details **and analysis**; excellent introduction and conclusion; strong topic sentences
Mechanics	many errors that get in the way of understanding	some errors; at times they get in the way	few errors; they occasionally get in the way	hardly any errors; they rarely get in the way

Score each criterion, add the three scores (maximum 12) and give a percentage, once for Draft 1 and again for the final draft. Rubric #2 weights the parts differently: content and organization 10 points, grammar and mechanics 25 points, format 5 points.

Your final essay: the course in one essay

Skill	Lessons
a focused, arguable thesis; strong introduction and conclusion	22, 24, 26
evidence from sources: paraphrase, summary and quotation, introduced, explained and cited	14, 15, 35-39
concession and counterargument; hedging	44, 45
cohesion: transitions, known-to-new order, summary nouns, links between paragraphs	27, 28
academic style: voice, clarity, concision, tone, word choice, sentence variety	46-49
mechanics: punctuation, confused words, spelling, word forms	6-8, 50, 51

> **In psychology:** use APA style: author-date citations in the text, such as (Smith, 2020), and a References list, not the MLA Works Cited style of some of the course's model essays.
>
> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic essays often open with a very broad statement and close with a proverb or a moral (compare Sample Essay #5). In an English academic essay, start close to your topic and end with your thesis and its significance. - English academic readers expect hedges (may, tends to, suggests) for claims you cannot fully prove; strong words such as "all", "always" and "certainly" need strong evidence.

Practice

Exercise 1. Qualities of good writing. Read "Qualities of Good Writing" in the lesson material.

1. What are Bailey's three qualities of good college writing?
2. Which three qualities does the book add?
3. Is writing that is easy to read the same as "dumbed down" writing? What can make complex ideas easy to read?
4. What is the "what's in it for me" strategy?
5. When audience expectations and standards conflict, what decides?
6. Why does the book say that writing is only "approaching" effectiveness?

Exercise 2. Edit two student paragraphs. Correct the errors in grammar and word choice in the Sample Introductory Paragraph ("A happy family is a beautiful dream…") and the Sample Concluding Paragraph ("In conclusion, everyone has different way to remove stress…").

Exercise 3. Overgeneralization and hedging. Read Sample Paragraph/Composition #2 ("I lived in Vietnam for 14 years…"). Find four claims that are too strong or that need evidence, and rewrite them in an academic way.

Exercise 4. Use the rubric. Read Sample Essay #3 ("There are so many people in this world…"). Score it with Rubric #1 and give a reason for each score. Then find and correct eight errors.

Exercise 5. From topic to thesis. Read the suggested writing topics in the lesson material. Write a working thesis for topic 12 (ways to deal with stress) and topic 36 (learning by doing, reading or listening).

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my thesis and outline for the final essay: [paste]. Is the thesis focused and arguable? Which paragraph needs more evidence?"
- "Score my draft with Rubric #1 (development, organization, mechanics, 1 to 4 each). Explain each score and name the one change that would raise my score the most."
- "Take the opposite side of my thesis and argue with me for five turns. Then tell me which counterargument my essay must answer."
- "Review the whole course with me: ask me ten questions about thesis statements, citing sources, hedging, cohesion and style. Then tell me which skills I should keep practising."
- "Help me plan how to keep improving my academic English through my PSYC 110 reading and writing."

Read aloud

1. The truly excellent writer is one who can explain complex ideas in a way that the reader can understand.

2. By opening with a "what's in it for me" strategy, | you give your audience a reason to be interested in what you've written.
3. Some argue that this has led to a decreased attention span for reading.
4. Writing is both a process and a product.
5. Good writing is characterized by correctness, | ease of reading, | and attractiveness.

Writing task

Final essay. Write an argumentative research essay of 1,000-1,500 words on one of these topics:

- **Psychology:** What are some good ways to deal with stress and minimize its negative impact on our lives? (book topic 12; PSYC 110 lectures on emotions and on mental illness; the chapter "Stress, Lifestyle, and Health" in OpenStax Psychology 2e)
- **Psychology:** Do you learn better by doing things, reading things, or listening to people talk about things? (book topic 36; memory in PSYC 110)
- A book topic: 13 (why many students never finish their first year of college), 15 (encouraging children to be very competitive), 29 (why many people are afraid of growing old) or 39 (early formal schooling or more time for play).

Required parts:

1. An introduction that shows the reader "what's in it for me" and ends with a clear, arguable thesis.
2. Three or four body paragraphs with strong topic sentences, evidence and your own analysis.
3. At least four credible sources (Google Scholar, PubMed Central, ERIC, the Directory of Open Access Journals, OpenStax Psychology 2e), introduced with reporting verbs and cited in APA style, with a References list.
4. One paragraph that concedes a fair opposing point and answers it.
5. Hedged claims where your evidence is limited.
6. A conclusion that restates the thesis and explains why it matters.

Process: outline, Draft 1, score it with Rubric #1, ask your tutor for a second assessment, revise, then score the final draft again.

Self-editing checklist:

- Development: Is my thesis clear, focused and arguable, and does every paragraph support it?
- Organization: Does each body paragraph have a strong topic sentence, evidence and analysis?
- Sources: Is every paraphrase, quotation and statistic cited in the text and in the References? Are my paraphrases really in my own words?
- Argument: Have I answered at least one counterargument fairly?
- Hedging: Have I removed overgeneralizations such as "all", "always" and "never" where my evidence is limited?
- Cohesion: Do transitions and summary nouns link my sentences and paragraphs?
- Style: Is my tone formal and consistent, my wording precise and my sentence types varied?

- Mechanics: Have I checked confused words, spelling, word forms and punctuation against my error log?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. It follows certain academic rules; it is easy to read and engaging; it attracts the reader.
2. It meets the reader's expectations; it is clear and concise; it is efficient and effective.
3. No. A brilliant illustrative example, definitions of unfamiliar words within the text, and dynamic, specific verbs that show what is happening and who is acting.
4. Stating at the beginning how your writing meets the reader's needs (for example, it answers a question or solves a problem), so that the reader has a reason to be interested.
5. Reader understanding.
6. Because writing is both a process and a product: it always needs more effort, attention and revision.

Exercise 2 (example answer; other corrections are possible)

- Introduction: A happy family is a beautiful dream **for** everybody in the world. What is a happy family? In my opinion, my family is a happy family because we usually spend a lot of time **doing activities together** on **special days**, such as my **mother's** birthday or Lunar New **Year**. **Two activities are special in my family at Lunar New Year: cooking traditional cakes and decorating our house.**
- Conclusion: In conclusion, everyone has **a** different way to **relieve** stress. Everyone should find the best way, **the one** that **makes him or her** more comfortable, to relieve stress and **relax**. Some people do not try to relieve stress**;** they just keep it inside. These people **may be more likely** to have high blood pressure, so everyone should find a way to relieve stress and never keep it inside. (In an academic essay, the health claim needs a source.)

Exercise 3 (example answer)

1. "All American are obeying the rules while they drive": "In my experience, most American drivers obey traffic rules."
2. "there are less car accidents on the roads": "there appear to be fewer car accidents" (with a statistic and a source).
3. "every minute will have at least one person die because of the car accident": a statistic needs a source; without one, write "road accidents cause many deaths in Vietnam".
4. "trash is everywhere in Vietnam": "trash is common on many roads in Vietnam". Also possible: "They are doing handshakes, hugs, and kisses to others": "Many Americans greet others with a handshake or a hug." Also correct the comparison "bigger and cleaner than Vietnam": "than those in Vietnam".

Exercise 4 (example scores; a range of one point is reasonable)

- Development 3: a clear thesis that names three characteristics, but its list is not parallel.
- Organization 2: introduction, three body paragraphs with topic sentences and a one-sentence conclusion; each point has only one short personal example, with little analysis.

- Mechanics 2: several errors, and some get in the way of understanding ("olympic trails").
- Total 7/12 (58%).

Errors (any eight): A persons: A person's; For example, Most: most; your bringing: you're bringing; accidently: accidentally; repay me back: repay me; olympics: Olympics; olympic trails: Olympic trials; In conclusion, It: it; in baseball practice: at baseball practice; "Therefore, he made it to..." does not follow logically: delete "Therefore"; "positivity, loving, and goal oriented" is not parallel: "being positive, loving and goal-oriented".

Exercise 5 (example answers)

- Topic 12: "Although no single method works for everyone, regular exercise and strong social support appear to be among the most effective ways for college students to reduce the harmful effects of stress."
- Topic 36: "Although many students believe that they learn best in one way, research suggests that most people remember more when they actively test themselves than when they only read or listen."

My notes